



All smiles: (Left to right) **1.** Jyothi Yarraji and Animesh Kujur celebrate their 200m golds; **2.** Records were set by multiple weightlifters, including Bindyarani Devi in the women's 55kg category; **3.** Moumita Mondal won gold in the women's long jump. PICS: RITU RAJ KONWAR. **4.** Dhinidhi Desinghu set new national records in the women's 400m and 200m freestyle categories, picking up 11 medals, including nine golds. PIC: STAN RAYAN

THE FUTURE SHONE BRIGHT IN UTTARAKHAND

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By any measure, the 38th National Games that concluded on February 14 should count as among the most ambitious domestic sports tournaments undertaken in India. Over 18 days, some 10,000 athletes competed in 35 disciplines spread across eight locations in Uttarakhand. The Games lived up to expectations — a high-level event, producing competitive performances with a host of new faces to watch out for.

This undertaking came with its fair share of challenges.

The scheduling was not ideal. The previous two editions in Gujarat (2022) and Goa (2023) were held towards the end of the international calendar, which meant participating athletes were at the peak of their abilities.

This time around, the Games were bracketed between the last week of January and the second week of February — a particularly awkward time in the international calendar. Barring Sarabjot Singh and Swapnil Kusale, none of India's other Olympic medallists took part in the competition. Track and field athletes were still coming off

their off-season. Some shooters noted that the late winter cold in the hill state stiffened their fingers and made it harder to gauge their trigger pulls.

There were issues before the Games began too. Although players with roots in Uttarakhand have been counted among India's greatest athletes, most — like Abhinav Bindra, Jaspal Rana, Lakshya Sen, and Rishabh Pant — have had to make their careers elsewhere. With its hilly terrain and lack of sporting facilities, the state has found it hard to develop as a sports hub.

Keeping the National Games in mind, a massive effort was made to develop infrastructure. According to official estimates, some 1,000 crore rupees were spent in preparation. A shooting hall was built from scratch at the Maharana Pratap Sports Complex in Dehradun, along with a